

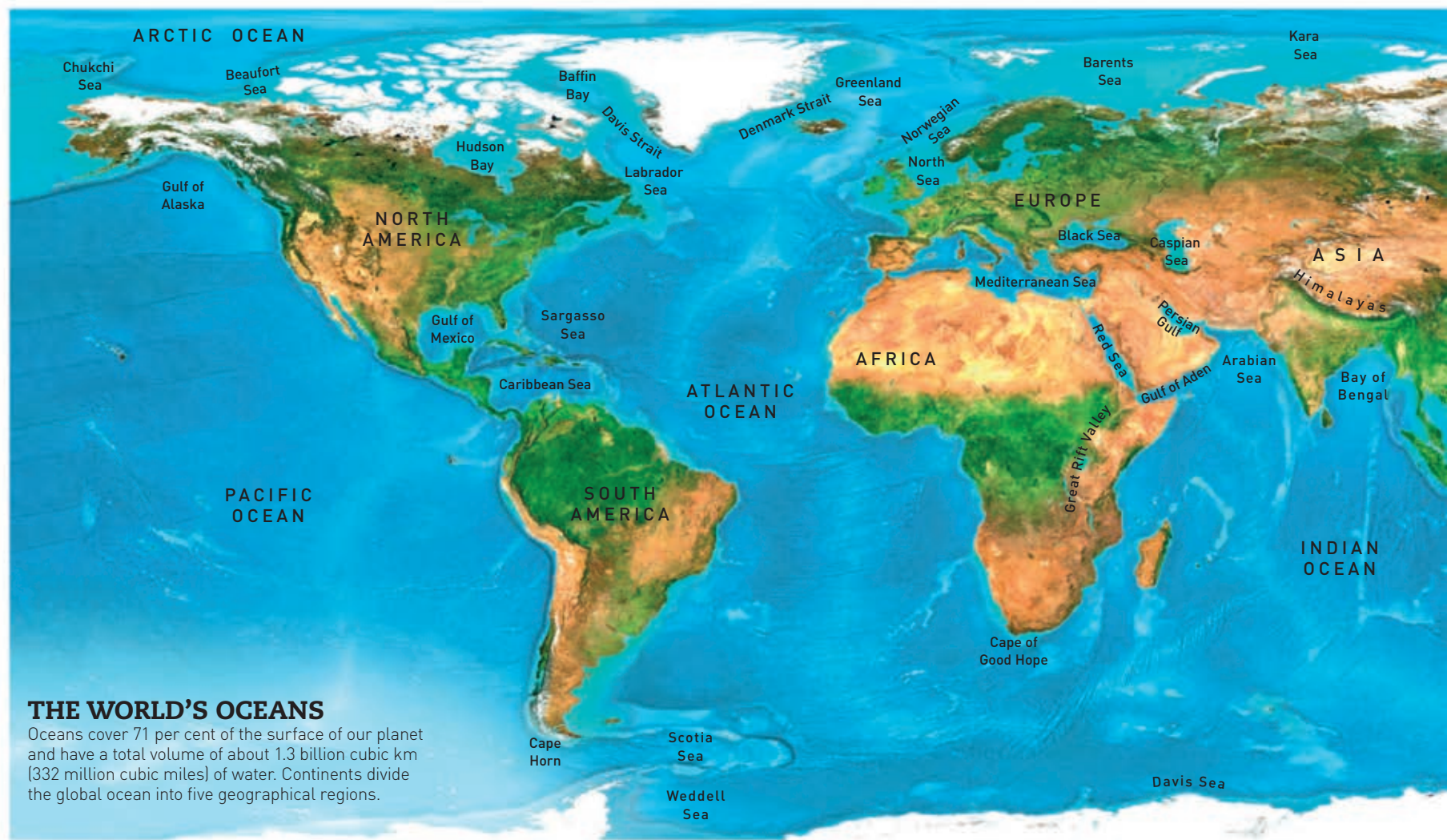
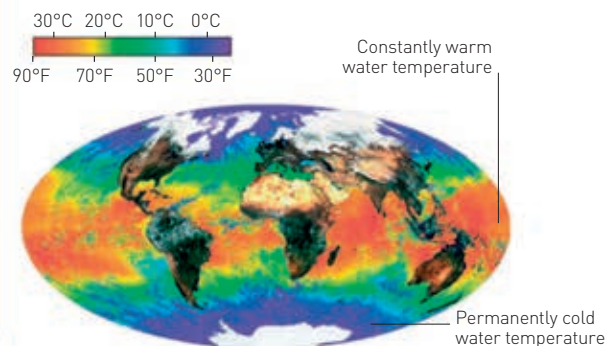
Water on Earth

**ABOUT 97 PER CENT OF
THE WORLD'S WATER
LIES IN THE OCEANS**

Water is the most common substance on Earth's surface – it fills the colossal oceans, swirls in clouds as water vapour, and falls as rain on land. It is vital to all life and is why our planet is unique: water vapour and ice may exist on other planets but only Earth has oceans of liquid water.

WATER TEMPERATURE

Deep-ocean water is permanently cold, but the temperature of surface water varies. It is warmest around the equator, where the Sun's heat is more intense. But in the polar regions, the Sun is less powerful, resulting in permanently cold water.

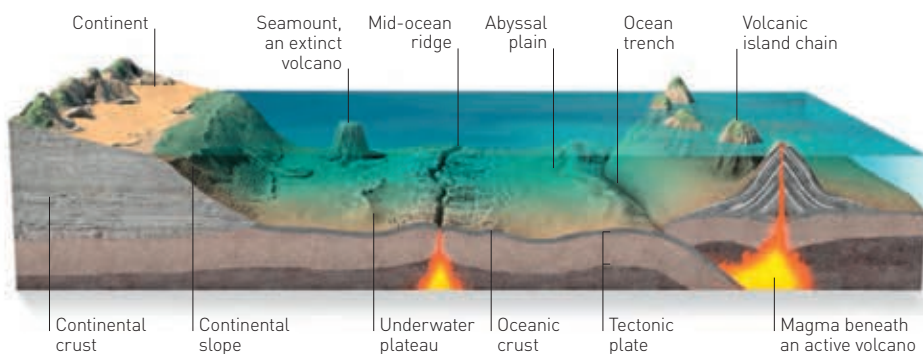


THE WORLD'S OCEANS

Oceans cover 71 per cent of the surface of our planet and have a total volume of about 1.3 billion cubic km (332 million cubic miles) of water. Continents divide the global ocean into five geographical regions.

OCEAN FLOOR

The ocean floor is not just a featureless plain filled with water. Underwater volcanoes, towering mountains, vast plains, and the deepest trenches on Earth lie hidden beneath the waves.



SALT WATER

Most of Earth's water is salty. Over millions of years, rain pouring down on the land weathered the rocks and carried dissolved minerals on its journey to the seas. The minerals included sodium chloride (common salt). This process is still happening today.

